



Vision forward: The Dallas stadium's most extravagant feature is its giant video board. Charlotte says it was never intended simply as a symbol of excess, but as a way of democratising the experience inside a vast building. AP

how little she treats the Cowboys as merely a football team.

In Charlotte's telling, the Cowboys are a community engine, a real-estate strategy, a media business, a hospitality company, a year-round gathering point and, above all, a cultural institution that has to justify its place in people's lives every day rather than ten Sundays a year.

That, more than any on-field record, is the story of how the Cowboys became the world's most valuable team. "It's interesting because it has been just the opposite of that," Charlotte says, when asked how the Cowboys have built such enormous financial value without the championship success that normally underpins sporting greatness.

"We haven't had great success on the field since the '90s. We won championships in the '90s. We've been competitive, but we haven't gotten back there. So, the past 30 years, the financial success has been based on everything but that."

That answer gets to the heart of the Cowboys story. The organisation learned early that it could not rely solely on on-field success to drive the business. If championships were not

guaranteed, then the franchise had to become indispensable in other ways through sponsorship, television, merchandising, stadium economics, real estate and, above all, through a relationship with its supporters that outlasted players, coaches and seasons.

When the Jones family bought the Cowboys in 1989, the team was haemorrhaging money. It was losing around \$75,000 a day, a staggering figure for an ownership group that had committed nearly "all of its financial resources" to the purchase. "There were no resources left over to keep feeding it," Charlotte recalls. "So, we had to find a way to stop the loss and figure out how to turn cash flow."

That urgency became the mother of reinvention.

The first frontier was sponsorship. In the old NFL model, corporate involvement was little more than visibility — a logo in the stadium, a board outside it, an advertising relationship. The Cowboys wanted to turn that into something deeper and more valuable.

"Back then, corporate partnerships were just advertising," Charlotte says. "You put a sign in the

stadium or a sign outside of the stadium, and that was just advertising. We created a partnership — what is now called sponsorship — where we did more with that partner than just put their name on there. We embedded with them. It was, 'Okay, we're going to connect our fans to your product, and we're going to help you drive the sales of your product, and in turn we become more valuable to you.'"

Television was another turning point. Charlotte remembers one of the Cowboys' earliest ownership meetings, when a network partner came asking to reduce its rights fee because it was struggling to make the economics work. "They said, 'We want to cut what we're paying you. We can't make this work. We are not making enough money,'" she recalls.

Jerry Jones refused. "My father said, 'No, you actually need to pay us more.'" At that point Rupert Murdoch was trying to build Fox into a national television force and saw sport as the vehicle to do it.

"He said, 'I will double that fee to get in. But don't just use me to make them pay more. You have to accept my bid, and I will build my station off of that.'"